

T E S T R E F E R E N C E G U I D E

GRE, GMAT, TOEFL & IELTS

A Complete Practical Guide to Graduate Admissions and Scholarship Testing

Audience: Students and scholarship applicants applying worldwide

Scope: Exam mechanics, preparation, registration, costs, score benchmarks

Edition: September 2026

Table of Contents

Executive Summary.....	1
1. Introduction: The Four Exams at a Glance.....	2
1.1 Purpose and Scope of This Guide.....	2
1.2 Aptitude Tests and English Tests: Two Different Jobs.....	2
2. Understanding Each Examination.....	3
2.1 The GRE (Graduate Record Examinations).....	3
2.2 The GMAT (Graduate Management Admission Test).....	4
2.3 The TOEFL iBT (Test of English as a Foreign Language, Internet-Based Test).....	5
2.4 The IELTS (International English Language Testing System).....	5
2.5 GRE or GMAT: How to Choose.....	6
2.6 TOEFL or IELTS: How to Choose.....	6
3. How to Prepare and Train.....	7
3.1 Principles That Apply to All Four Exams.....	7
3.2 Preparing for the GRE.....	7
3.3 Preparing for the GMAT.....	8
3.4 Preparing for the TOEFL iBT.....	8
3.5 Preparing for the IELTS.....	9
3.6 Resource Summary by Exam.....	10
4. Registering and Sitting the Exams.....	10
4.1 Registering for the GRE.....	10
4.2 Registering for the GMAT.....	11
4.3 Registering for the TOEFL iBT.....	11
4.4 Registering for the IELTS.....	12
4.5 Test Center or At Home: Which to Choose.....	12
4.6 What Happens on Test Day.....	13
5. Costs, Fees and Financial Planning.....	14

5.1 What Each Exam Costs.....	14
5.2 The Hidden Costs Worth Budgeting.....	14
5.3 Fee Reductions and Waivers.....	15
6. Score Benchmarks for Scholarships and Admissions.....	15
6.1 How Committees Actually Read Scores.....	15
6.2 GRE Benchmarks.....	16
6.3 GMAT Benchmarks.....	16
6.4 TOEFL and IELTS Benchmarks.....	17
6.5 What Major Scholarships Actually Require.....	18
6.6 Keeping Scores Valid and Getting Them Where They Belong.....	19
7. Policies, Retakes and Practical Logistics.....	20
7.1 Retake Rules Compared.....	20
7.2 Accommodations for Disabilities and Health Conditions.....	21
7.3 Common Mistakes and How to Avoid Them.....	21
8. Building Your Personal Testing Roadmap.....	22
8.1 A Twelve-Month Plan Working Backwards from Deadlines.....	22
8.2 A Decision Checklist Before You Register.....	23
9. Frequently Asked Questions.....	23
10. Final Recommendations.....	25

Note: This Table of Contents is generated via field codes. To ensure page number accuracy after editing, please right-click the TOC and select "Update Field."

Executive Summary

This guide explains, in one place, everything an international student needs to know about the four standardized examinations that dominate graduate admissions and scholarship applications worldwide: the **GRE** (Graduate Record Examinations), the **GMAT** (Graduate Management Admission Test), the **TOEFL iBT** (Test of English as a Foreign Language) and the **IELTS** (International English Language Testing System). It covers what each test measures, how each is scored, how to prepare and train for them effectively, where and how to register and sit the exams, what the tests cost, and, most importantly, which scores are actually needed for the results to be valuable when applying to scholarships and funded programs.

The four exams fall into two distinct families, and almost every applicant to a program taught in English needs one from each family. The GRE and GMAT are **aptitude tests**: they assess quantitative reasoning, verbal reasoning and analytical writing, and they are used by universities to compare applicants from very different academic backgrounds. The TOEFL and IELTS are **English proficiency tests**: they certify that you can read, listen, speak and write in English at the level required to survive in a graduate classroom. A high GRE score cannot compensate for a missing English certificate, and an excellent IELTS band cannot replace a required GMAT score.

The practical benchmarks that matter for scholarships are straightforward. For English tests, an IELTS overall band of **6.5 to 7.0** or a TOEFL iBT score of **90 to 100** clears the stated minimum of most major scholarship programs, while competitive applicants typically present IELTS 7.5 or TOEFL 105 and above. For aptitude tests, a GRE total of **315 to 320+** (Verbal plus Quantitative) or a GMAT Focus Edition score of **645+** places an applicant in the competitive range for merit-based funding at strong programs. Scores from the GRE and GMAT remain valid for five years, while TOEFL and IELTS scores expire after two years, so the English test should generally be taken first and the aptitude test second, with both arranged to still be valid at the time of application.

Each chapter of this guide is self-contained: Chapter 1 gives a rapid overview, Chapters 2 to 5 explain the exams, preparation, registration and costs, Chapter 6 provides detailed score benchmark tables for scholarships, Chapters 7 and 8 cover policies and planning, and Chapters 9 and 10 answer the most common questions and summarize recommended actions.

1. Introduction: The Four Exams at a Glance

1.1 Purpose and Scope of This Guide

Applying to a master's degree, a doctorate or an MBA abroad usually means confronting a wall of acronyms: GRE, GMAT, TOEFL, IELTS, and sometimes PTE or Duolingo English Test. The information is scattered across official websites that describe formats in dense technical language, and across forums where advice is often outdated or contradictory. This guide consolidates that information into a single, practical reference written for a student who is exploring their options and needs accurate, actionable detail.

The scope of the guide is deliberately complete. It explains what each examination contains and how it is scored; how to choose between GRE and GMAT, and between TOEFL and IELTS; how to build an effective preparation plan using free and paid resources; how to register, where the exams are held and what happens on test day; what everything costs and where fee reductions exist; which scores make applications competitive for major international scholarships; and how to sequence everything into a realistic twelve-month roadmap. Fees and policies change periodically, so every figure in this document should be confirmed on the official websites listed in Chapter 9 before you pay.

1.2 Aptitude Tests and English Tests: Two Different Jobs

The most common source of confusion for first-time applicants is assuming that the four exams are interchangeable. They are not. The **GRE**, owned and administered by ETS (Educational Testing Service, United States), is accepted by graduate programs across nearly every discipline, from engineering to public policy, and increasingly by business schools as well. The **GMAT**, owned by GMAC (Graduate Management Admission Council), is designed specifically for business and management admissions and is the traditional benchmark for MBA programs. Both tests assume you already speak English fluently and measure reasoning skill instead.

The **TOEFL iBT**, also owned by ETS, and the **IELTS**, jointly owned by the British Council, IDP Education and Cambridge Assessment English, do the opposite: they measure English language ability and assume nothing about your academic aptitude. American and Canadian institutions have historically favored the TOEFL, while the IELTS dominates in the United Kingdom, Australia and much of Europe, although today both are accepted almost everywhere. Table 1 summarizes the four exams side by side, and the chapters that follow examine each one in detail.

Table 1: The four examinations at a glance

Exam	What it measures	Owner	Length	Score scale	Validity	Typical fee
GRE	Academic aptitude: verbal, quantitative, analytical writing	ETS (USA)	About 2 hours	130-170 per section (Verbal, Quantitative); 0-6 Writing	5 years	About US\$220, varies by country
GMAT Focus Edition	Business aptitude: quantitative, verbal, data insights	GMAC	2 hours 15 minutes	205-805 total; 60-90 per section	5 years	US\$275 center, US\$300 online
TOEFL iBT	Academic English: reading, listening, speaking, writing	ETS (USA)	Under 2 hours	0-120 total; 0-30 per skill	2 years	About US\$195-270, varies by country
IELTS Academic	General English: listening, reading, writing, speaking	British Council, IDP, Cambridge	About 2h45 plus separate speaking	Bands 0-9 in 0.5 steps	2 years	About US\$215-340 equivalent, varies widely

Two practical observations follow directly from this table. First, because aptitude scores last five years and English scores only two, it is usually wise to take the GRE or GMAT early and schedule the TOEFL or IELTS closer to the application window, so that nothing expires before admission. Second, the two families serve as independent filters in scholarship evaluation: selection committees check the English certificate first (as a pass or fail gate) and then compare aptitude scores between candidates who passed that gate.

2. Understanding Each Examination

2.1 The GRE (Graduate Record Examinations)

The GRE General Test is the broadest graduate admissions test in the world and is accepted by thousands of master's and doctoral programs in the United States, Canada, Europe and beyond. Since September 2023 the test has been delivered in a shortened format lasting just

under two hours, with no unscored experimental section. It contains three measured components. **Analytical Writing** consists of a single task, Analyze an Issue, completed in 30 minutes and scored from 0 to 6 in half-point increments. **Verbal Reasoning** is delivered in two sections containing 12 and 15 questions respectively, with 18 and 23 minutes allowed, and tests reading comprehension, text completion and sentence equivalence; it is scored from 130 to 170. **Quantitative Reasoning** is also delivered in two sections of 12 and 15 questions, with 21 and 26 minutes allowed, covering arithmetic, algebra, geometry and data analysis, and is scored from 130 to 170.

The test is section-level adaptive, meaning the difficulty of your second Verbal section and second Quantitative section depends on how well you performed on the first. There is no calculator for Verbal and an on-screen calculator is provided for Quantitative questions. Two features matter greatly for scholarship applicants. The first is **ScoreSelect**, which lets you choose, after each test administration, which scores ETS sends to institutions, so a weaker earlier attempt can be withheld. The second is the free score reporting: on test day you may designate four institutions to receive scores at no charge. A GRE Subject Test in mathematics, physics or psychology still exists at US\$199, but very few programs require it today, so the General Test is what almost every applicant needs.

2.2 The GMAT (Graduate Management Admission Test)

The GMAT Focus Edition, introduced in November 2023 and now the only version offered, is the standard admissions test for MBA programs and specialized business master's degrees such as finance, management and marketing. It runs 2 hours and 15 minutes across three equally weighted sections, each 45 minutes long. **Quantitative Reasoning** (21 questions) focuses on algebra and applied problem solving; the separate geometry component was removed in the Focus Edition. **Verbal Reasoning** (23 questions) tests reading comprehension and critical reasoning, with sentence correction removed. **Data Insights** (20 questions) is the newest and most distinctive section, combining data sufficiency, table interpretation, graph analysis and multi-source reasoning, and it permits use of an on-screen calculator. You may choose the order of the sections and take one optional 10-minute break, and within each section you can bookmark and change up to three answers before submitting.

The total score ranges from **205 to 805** in ten-point intervals, with each section reported from 60 to 90; the essay (Analytical Writing Assessment) no longer exists on the Focus Edition. Because the scale changed, admissions offices publish conversion guidance: a Focus Edition score of about **645** is positioned as equivalent to the old 700, and about **705** as equivalent to the old 750. The GMAT costs US\$275 at a test center or US\$300 online in most countries, scores remain valid for five years, and you may send five free score reports within 48 hours of viewing your official score.

2.3 The TOEFL iBT (Test of English as a Foreign Language, Internet-Based Test)

The TOEFL iBT is ETS's academic English test, accepted by more than 12,000 institutions, with its strongest presence in the United States and Canada. Since the July 2023 revision it lasts under two hours and contains four sections. **Reading** (20 questions, 35 minutes) presents two academic passages. **Listening** (28 questions, 36 minutes) presents lectures and campus conversations. **Speaking** (4 tasks, 16 minutes) requires recorded responses prepared in 15 to 30 seconds and delivered in 45 to 60 seconds; there is no human interviewer, which many candidates find less stressful. **Writing** (2 tasks, 29 minutes) consists of an integrated task based on reading and listening material and an academic discussion task in which you contribute to an online classroom debate. Each skill is scored from 0 to 30, giving a total out of 120.

A distinctive TOEFL feature is **MyBest scores**: ETS reports both the scores from a single test date and the highest section scores achieved across all your TOEFL attempts within the last two years. Some universities and scholarship programs accept MyBest scores while others insist on single-date scores, so read the requirement carefully. The test is offered at authorized centers and in a home edition with strict room and equipment requirements, and fees vary by country, commonly falling between US\$195 and US\$270.

2.4 The IELTS (International English Language Testing System)

IELTS is the world's most widely taken English test and the traditional requirement in the United Kingdom, Australia, Ireland and much of Europe. Two versions exist: **IELTS Academic**, required for university admission, and **IELTS General Training**, used for migration; scholarship applicants always need the Academic version. The test has four components. **Listening** (30 minutes, 40 questions) is the same in both versions. **Academic Reading** (60 minutes, 40 questions) uses three long texts. **Academic Writing** (60 minutes) requires a 150-word description of a chart, graph or diagram in Task 1 and a 250-word essay in Task 2. **Speaking** (11 to 14 minutes) is a face-to-face interview with a certified examiner, sometimes scheduled on a different day from the written papers; this human interaction is the clearest difference from the TOEFL and candidates who speak confidently often prefer it.

Results are reported as **band scores from 0 to 9** in half-band increments for each skill, and the overall band is the average of the four, rounded to the nearest half band. The test can be taken on paper or on computer, and in some countries an at-home IELTS Online option exists. Unlike the other three exams, IELTS offers **One Skill Retake** in many countries: if your overall band was held back by a single weak skill, you can retake just that component on computer rather than the whole test. Results are valid for two years, and up to five official copies are sent to institutions free of charge.

2.5 GRE or GMAT: How to Choose

For MBA applicants the choice has largely dissolved, because most business schools now accept both tests without preference; admissions committees convert scores to a common scale for internal comparison. The choice therefore becomes strategic rather than formal. The **GMAT** signals commitment to a business career and its Data Insights section is closely watched by quantitatively oriented programs; strong GMAT performance remains the benchmark for MBA merit scholarships. The **GRE** keeps every door open: one preparation effort serves MBA applications, public policy programs, engineering master's degrees and PhD applications alike, which makes it the efficient choice for applicants who have not fully settled on a field.

A reasonable rule of thumb is the following. If you are certain about business school, prepare for the GMAT and target the published middle-50 percent range of your chosen programs. If you are exploring several fields or applying to both, take the GRE, because its quantitative score is accepted everywhere the GMAT is, while the reverse is not always true. Candidates strong in vocabulary and reading tend to find the GRE Verbal friendlier, while candidates strong in logic and data tend to prefer the GMAT's more compact verbal section. Taking both exams purely to compare scores is expensive and rarely necessary; a diagnostic practice test of each, which is free, provides the same information at no cost.

2.6 TOEFL or IELTS: How to Choose

Both tests are accepted by the overwhelming majority of universities and by every major scholarship program, so the first filter is always the official requirement list of your target institutions: if a specific scholarship states that it accepts only IELTS Academic or prefers TOEFL, that single line ends the debate. Where both are accepted, choose by format preference and destination. The **TOEFL** is fully computer-based, including the speaking section recorded to a microphone, and its academic register suits candidates comfortable with lectures and note-taking; it remains the default choice for applicants to the United States and Canada.

The **IELTS** combines computer or paper-based written papers with a live, face-to-face speaking interview, and its General Training version additionally serves migration routes, which matters for applicants weighing post-study work visas. For orientation, the two scales convert approximately as follows: IELTS 6.5 corresponds to TOEFL 79 to 93, IELTS 7.0 to TOEFL 94 to 101, and IELTS 7.5 to TOEFL 102 to 109, although each institution sets its own equivalences. Whichever you choose, remember that scores expire after two years, so the test should be taken within two years of your application date, not before.

3. How to Prepare and Train

3.1 Principles That Apply to All Four Exams

Effective preparation for every one of these tests rests on the same small set of principles, and ignoring them is the most common reason candidates underperform relative to their ability. Begin with a **diagnostic**: take one full official practice test under strict timed conditions before studying anything, so that your starting point, your section weaknesses and your pacing problems are visible in numbers rather than impressions. Then build a written schedule working backwards from your test date, allocating 8 to 15 hours per week over 2 to 4 months for an aptitude test, or 4 to 10 hours per week over 1 to 3 months for an English test, depending on your starting level.

Three habits separate successful candidates from frustrated ones. First, prioritize **official materials** over third-party content, because only official questions replicate the real difficulty, wording and scoring logic; every prep company's questions are approximations. Second, keep an **error log**: a running document recording every practice question you missed, why you missed it, and the rule or vocabulary involved; reviewing this log weekly is worth more than solving hundreds of new questions. Third, rehearse under **real conditions**, meaning full sections on a screen, timed, without pausing, because test-day stamina and pacing are trainable skills that un-timed study never develops. Reserve the final two weeks before the exam for full mock tests and review rather than new content.

3.2 Preparing for the GRE

GRE preparation has three distinct battlefronts. For **Verbal**, vocabulary is the foundation: the test draws on a well-documented corpus of academic words, and learning roughly 1,000 to 1,500 high-frequency GRE words with their connotations, using spaced-repetition flashcards such as Anki or Quizlet decks, produces visible score movement within weeks. Reading comprehension then requires daily practice with dense texts from *The Economist*, *Scientific American* or similar sources, trained by summarizing each paragraph in one line. For **Quantitative**, most candidates need to rebuild high-school mathematics: arithmetic, algebra, geometry, statistics and probability, for which the free Khan Academy syllabus is the standard repair tool, followed by official quantitative questions to learn the test's specific trick structures, especially quantitative comparison questions.

For **Analytical Writing**, study the published scoring criteria and practice writing complete issue essays in 30 minutes, focusing on a clear position, organized paragraphs and precise language rather than length. The core official resources are the **POWERPREP Online** practice tests on ets.org, which include two free full-length tests that replicate the adaptive algorithm, plus the Official Guide to the GRE General Test. Widely used third-party options include GregMat's inexpensive video course, Magoosh's question bank and videos, and the

Manhattan Prep 5 lb. Book of Practice Problems for volume drilling. A realistic total effort for a score improvement of 10 or more points is 100 to 200 hours spread over 3 to 4 months.

3.3 Preparing for the GMAT

GMAT preparation is a game of precision and pacing across three sections. **Quantitative Reasoning** rewards re-deriving fundamentals until algebra and arithmetic manipulation are automatic, because the section's difficulty comes from clever setups under time pressure, not from advanced content. **Verbal Reasoning** is dominated by critical reasoning, so train yourself to identify argument structure, assumption and flaw before looking at the answer choices; reading comprehension passages are shorter than the GRE's but denser in business content. **Data Insights**, the section most applicants have never practiced in school, needs the most time: work through every official Data Sufficiency and Table Analysis question available, learn when the on-screen calculator helps and when it wastes seconds, and practice multi-source reasoning until juggling three tabs of data feels routine.

The official starting point is mba.com, which offers a free official starter kit including two full-length practice exams with the real scoring algorithm; the Official Guide and its section-specific volumes provide the question pool. Highly regarded structured courses include Target Test Prep, known for deep quantitative coverage, e-GMAT for verbal, and Manhattan Prep's interactivity. Because the Focus Edition scores sections equally, a balanced 3-section strategy outperforms over-investing in one strength: a candidate aiming at 645 or above typically needs section scores around the low-to-mid 80s in all three areas. Plan 100 to 150 hours of preparation over 2 to 3 months.

3.4 Preparing for the TOEFL iBT

TOEFL preparation is about acquiring academic English routines rather than new knowledge. For **Reading**, practice active passage mapping: note each paragraph's function in a few words, because questions cluster around structure as much as detail. For **Listening**, the crucial trainable skill is note-taking on lectures: abbreviations, arrows and structure symbols that capture main idea, examples and attitude, since half the test depends on notes you take. For **Speaking**, the fixed four-task format makes it the most coachable section: rehearse the 15-second preparation routine, record yourself daily on official-style questions, and listen back for filler words, grammar slips and pacing; a speaking partner or tutor reviewing recordings accelerates this dramatically. For **Writing**, learn the integrated task's template of summarizing the reading point, then contrasting the lecture's response, and practice the academic discussion format until a 100-word contribution with one clear position and two supports is automatic.

Official resources come first: the free full-length practice test on the TOEFL section of ets.org, the TOEFL TestReady platform with additional scored practice, and the Official

Guide to the TOEFL iBT Test. TST Prep and NoteFull are the most recommended independent course providers. Candidates starting from a solid intermediate level typically need 4 to 8 weeks; candidates starting weaker should extend to 3 months and consider general English work before test-specific drilling.

3.5 Preparing for the IELTS

IELTS preparation revolves around its four fixed question formats, which reward method as much as language. For **Listening**, practice the answer-transfer discipline (for paper tests) and the one-play-only rule: you hear each recording exactly once, so train predicting answer types from the question sheet before the audio starts. For **Academic Reading**, master skimming for gist and scanning for keywords, and be strict about the 20 minutes per passage rhythm; True-False-Not-Given questions deserve dedicated drilling because their logic is unlike anything else in English testing. For **Writing**, Task 1 requires learning a small repertoire of chart-description language (trends, comparisons, proportions) and Task 2 requires a reliable four-paragraph essay frame; examiners grade against public descriptors, so study band 7 and 8 sample scripts and have your own scripts marked against them. For **Speaking**, the face-to-face format means practicing with a real partner or teacher, developing extended answers around the familiar Part 1, Part 2 cue-card and Part 3 discussion structure.

The indispensable official resource is the Cambridge IELTS series of past paper books (recent volumes 15 to 19 are most representative), combined with the free **Road to IELTS** course offered through the British Council website and IDP's preparation materials. IELTS Liz and IELTS Simon provide widely respected free lessons, especially for writing. Because the speaking examiner and the writing markers are human, feedback from a qualified teacher on real scripts is the single highest-value investment most candidates can make.

3.6 Resource Summary by Exam

The table below consolidates the preparation toolkit for each exam, ordered so that the free official resources, which every candidate should exhaust first, appear before commercial options. None of the commercial listings are endorsements of a single path; they are simply the resources with the longest track records and the strongest reputations in candidate communities.

Table 2: Recommended preparation resources for each examination

Exam	Official (free first)	Books and courses	Approximate effort
GRE	POWERPREP Online (2 free tests); official quant and verbal practice sets on ets.org	Official Guide; Manhattan Prep 5 lb. Book; GregMat videos; Magoosh; Anki vocabulary decks	100-200 hours over 3-4 months
GMAT	mba.com starter kit with 2 free practice exams; official question packs	GMAT Official Guide 2024-25; Target Test Prep; e-GMAT; Manhattan Prep	100-150 hours over 2-3 months
TOEFL iBT	Free full practice test on ets.org; TOEFL TestReady; official Writing and Speaking samples	Official Guide to the TOEFL iBT; TST Prep; NoteFull	40-100 hours over 1-3 months
IELTS Academic	Road to IELTS (British Council); IDP free practice; official sample questions	Cambridge IELTS 15-19 past papers; IELTS Liz; IELTS Simon; teacher-marked scripts	40-100 hours over 1-3 months

4. Registering and Sitting the Exams

4.1 Registering for the GRE

Registration for the GRE happens entirely through the ETS account portal at **ets.org**. Create a MyGRE account using a name that matches your identification document character for character, select Register for the GRE General Test, choose between a test center appointment or the GRE at home option, and pay the fee by card or another accepted method. Test centers operate year-round in most countries with appointments typically available several times per week, while the at-home version can be booked around the clock in almost any time zone. International test-takers should present a **valid passport** as identification

unless ETS lists an alternative for their country, and the name on the account must match the passport exactly or you will be refused entry and lose the fee.

Rescheduling or changing the test center is possible for a fee (around US\$50 in the United States) if done at least a few days before the appointment, and ETS offers a **Fee Reduction Program** that halves the cost for eligible candidates with financial need; eligibility rules differ by country and are described in Chapter 5. On test day at a center, arrive 30 to 45 minutes early with your passport, store phones and bags in lockers, and expect security procedures including photography and signature capture. Score reports: four institutions can be designated free of charge on test day immediately after you view your unofficial Verbal, Quantitative and total scores, and ScoreSelect lets you decide per report whether to send that day's result or any previous one from the last five years.

4.2 Registering for the GMAT

The GMAT is scheduled through a single global portal at **mba.com**: create your account, complete the profile, choose between a test center appointment or the **GMAT Online** delivery, pick a date and time, and pay US\$275 (center) or US\$300 (online) in the United States, with equivalent local pricing elsewhere. The same passport rule applies: the ID you register with must be the document you present on exam day. Rescheduling fees are tiered according to how far in advance you make the change, so book a date you can realistically commit to. GMAC's fee waiver program works differently from ETS's: schools receive waiver codes and distribute them to candidates they invite, so applicants with financial constraints should ask target programs' admissions offices directly whether they participate.

On test day at a center you will complete check-in, store belongings, and sit the three sections in your chosen order with one optional 10-minute break. Online delivery uses a proctored setup with room scanning and strict desk requirements, and online scores are fully official and indistinguishable in reporting. After the exam you see your unofficial scores immediately and have 48 hours after the official score release to select up to **five free score reports** to institutions; additional reports cost US\$35 each.

4.3 Registering for the TOEFL iBT

TOEFL registration also runs through ets.org, using a separate TOEFL account from the GRE one. After choosing between a **test center** appointment and the **TOEFL iBT Home Edition**, select a date (weekends and some weekdays, with seats in high-demand cities filling early), pay the country-specific fee, and designate up to four institutions to receive free score reports; this selection can be made until 10 p.m. the evening before the test. The Home Edition requires specific conditions that must be maintained for the whole session: a private room, a clear desk, an approved browser with camera lockdown, and a stable internet connection, with the proctor able to cancel the session for violations.

Scores appear in your account approximately 4 to 8 days after the test, and official reports reach institutions within days of that. Because results are graded to the 0.5 band by human raters for speaking and writing, plan a margin of at least three weeks between the test and your first application deadline. If a score falls short, there is no formal limit on retaking the TOEFL beyond a short waiting period between attempts, but each attempt costs the full registration fee, which makes preparation the cheaper investment.

4.4 Registering for the IELTS

IELTS is booked through the organization that administers it in your country, either the **British Council** or **IDP Education**; both deliver the identical test and their websites include a test-location finder with live dates and fees. Choose **IELTS Academic** and then computer-delivered or paper-based: computer-delivered results arrive in 1 to 5 days and offer more frequent dates, while paper-based results take about 13 days. During booking you select the speaking slot where options exist (speaking may be held on a different day), enter the identity document details you will present at the test, and pay the local fee. The document used at registration, almost always a passport for international purposes, must be brought to both the written and speaking sessions.

Up to **five copies** of your Test Report Form are sent to institutions free of charge, and additional copies can be requested for a small fee. Candidates in most countries can also use **One Skill Retake** after a computer-delivered attempt: if only one skill fell short, you can re-sit that single skill within a limited window rather than the entire test, and a new Test Report Form is issued. Confirm with your target institutions that they accept results containing a One Skill Retake before relying on it.

4.5 Test Center or At Home: Which to Choose

All four exams can now be taken either at an authorized center or at home under live proctoring, and both routes produce fully official scores. The decision usually comes down to environment and reliability rather than validity. The comparison below summarizes the practical trade-offs.

Table 3: Test center versus at-home delivery

Consideration	Test center	At home
Scheduling	Fixed sessions, limited seats in busy cities	Very flexible, including evenings and weekends
Environment	Standardized hardware, staff on site	You must control room, desk, internet and camera for hours

Consideration	Test center	At home
Technical risk	Low; equipment managed by the center	Real risk: connection drops or software failures can void a session
Scoring and acceptance	Fully official everywhere	Fully official for GRE, GMAT, TOEFL; IELTS Online availability varies by country
Program perception	Never questioned	Valid, though a few competitive programs quietly favor center scores; verify if unsure

A sensible default is to take the exam at a center whenever a reachable one exists and to use the at-home option when travel is expensive, seats are scarce, or you perform better in a familiar setting. Whichever route you choose, run the official system check on the same computer and network days before the appointment, and read the current rules on breaks, scratch paper and whiteboards, which differ between the at-home and center versions of each exam.

4.6 What Happens on Test Day

The mechanics of test day are similar across all four exams, and small administrative mistakes are among the most avoidable causes of lost fees. Bring the **original identification document** you registered with; photocopies or digital images are rejected. Arrive early enough to absorb check-in queues, photography and locker procedures, typically 30 to 45 minutes. Personal items, including phones, watches and notes, stay in lockers outside the testing room. During aptitude tests, an on-screen calculator appears only where the design allows it (GRE Quantitative and the whole GMAT), and scrap paper or an erasable booklet is provided at centers, while at-home versions use an approved online whiteboard. English tests supply note-taking paper for the listening sections.

Pacing discipline matters as much as knowledge: every section has published timing, unofficial scores for the aptitude tests appear on screen at the end with the option to accept, cancel or, on the GMAT, view section performance before deciding, and the official reports follow within days to weeks depending on the exam. If something goes wrong technically, report it to the invigilator or proctor immediately and file a formal complaint before leaving, because retroactive remedies without a same-day record are rare.

5. Costs, Fees and Financial Planning

5.1 What Each Exam Costs

Registration fees differ by country for the English tests and by delivery mode for the GMAT, and all providers adjust prices periodically, so treat the figures below as planning estimates rather than quotations. The pattern that matters for budgeting is that the full journey, including preparation materials, one retake margin and extra score reports, usually costs between US\$600 and US\$1,200 for a candidate taking one aptitude test and one English test.

Table 4: Estimated costs by examination (confirm current prices on official sites)

Cost item	GRE	GMAT Focus	TOEFL iBT	IELTS Academic
Registration	About US\$220 worldwide, with country variations	US\$275 center, US\$300 online (US pricing)	About US\$195-270 depending on country	About US\$215-340 equivalent depending on country
Rescheduling	About US\$50 (US)	Tiered by notice period	About US\$60-70 (US)	Small administration fee, provider-specific
Extra score report	About US\$35 each	US\$35 each	About US\$25 each	Small fee per additional copy
Score review services	Available for a fee	Rescoring not offered (machine scored)	Speaking and Writing rescoring available	Enquiry on results service available

5.2 The Hidden Costs Worth Budgeting

The registration fee is rarely the whole expense. Preparation materials range from entirely free (official practice tests, Khan Academy, Road to IELTS, GregMat's low-cost subscription) to US\$200-500 for comprehensive commercial courses, and it is realistic to spend US\$50-150 on books or question banks even on a tight budget. Travel and accommodation arise when test centers are in another city, which is common in smaller countries, and at-home testing trades that cost against reliable electricity and internet, which itself may require backup arrangements. Retakes multiply everything: a candidate who budgets for two attempts per exam from the start avoids the stress of a single high-stakes day. Finally, remember that scores sent later outside the free allocation cost money each time, so decide your institution list carefully before test day, and keep a small reserve (about 10 percent of the total budget) for administration you cannot foresee.

5.3 Fee Reductions and Waivers

Several legitimate routes reduce these costs, although they differ sharply by citizenship and exam. The **GRE Fee Reduction Program** provides a voucher halving the General Test fee (paying US\$100) plus discounted Subject Tests and one free ScoreSelect report; it is administered through United States institutions and programs supporting students with financial need, so international applicants should enquire through EducationUSA advising centers or partner universities in their country. The **EducationUSA Opportunity Funds** program, active in selected countries, can cover test fees and related application costs for high-potential candidates from disadvantaged backgrounds. The **GMAT fee waiver** is distributed by participating business schools rather than by GMAC, and asking admissions offices directly is the standard procedure. The **TOEFL** offers a need-based reduction for eligible United States residents, and some national scholarship preparation programs purchase test vouchers for their cohorts. **IELTS** has no general waiver scheme, but scholarship preparatory organizations and some British Council country offices run subsidized or free test programs periodically.

Two practical notes complete the financial picture. First, apply for any waiver well before you plan to register, because processing can take weeks and vouchers cannot be applied retroactively to an existing booking. Second, some graduate schools and scholarship bodies refund or reimburse test fees after enrollment; a quick email to the admissions office asking about reimbursement policies sometimes recovers hundreds of dollars after you succeed.

6. Score Benchmarks for Scholarships and Admissions

6.1 How Committees Actually Read Scores

Understanding how scores are evaluated matters more than memorizing any single number. Programs publish **minimum requirements**, which function as eligibility gates: fall below them and your file is often filtered out before human review, particularly for scholarships where application volumes are enormous. What determines funding, however, is the **competitive range**, the middle-50 percent band of recently admitted and funded students, which typically sits well above the published minimum. Selection committees also read scores in context: a 312 GRE with an otherwise outstanding research profile beats a 325 attached to a weak file, but no research profile rescues a file that failed the English gate. Finally, section scores and component minimums matter as much as totals; many programs state a floor for each IELTS band or for GRE Quantitative separately, so a strong total with one weak component can still fail the requirement.

6.2 GRE Benchmarks

The GRE reports Verbal and Quantitative on a 130-170 scale each; totals below combine the two, and Analytical Writing is reported separately from 0 to 6. The table expresses widely used planning tiers. Treat them as orientation, not law: engineering and computer science programs concentrate on the Quantitative figure, humanities and social sciences on Verbal and Writing, while business schools convert totals internally.

Table 5: GRE score tiers and what they support

Tier	Total (V+Q)	Typical section profile	What it supports
Below minimum	Below 300	Writing under 3.0	Risky for admission anywhere selective; retake recommended
Meets floors	300-310	Q 155-160; V 150-155; AWA 3.5	Clears many program minimums; weak for funded places
Competitive	310-320	Q 160-165; V 155-160; AWA 4.0	Strong for funded master's and PhD places at good programs
Strong	320 and above	Q 165+; V 160+; AWA 4.5-5.0	Top programs and merit scholarships; Fulbright-selected median is about 315

6.3 GMAT Benchmarks

GMAT Focus Edition scores run from 205 to 805, and the equivalence anchors help translate advice written for the older scale: about **645 Focus corresponds to the classic 700**, and about **705 Focus to the classic 750**. Business schools publish class profiles with middle-80 percent ranges; scholarships at those schools usually go to candidates in the upper half of that range or above it.

Table 6: GMAT Focus Edition score tiers

Tier	Focus Edition score	Classic equivalent	What it supports
Below typical	Below 555	Below 600	Below most reputable program floors
Meets floors	555-615	600-650	Meets many solid program minimums

Tier	Focus Edition score	Classic equivalent	What it supports
Competitive	615-645	650-700	Competitive for admission and partial awards
Strong	645-705	700-750	Merit scholarships at strong MBA programs become realistic
Elite	705 and above	750 and above	Top programs; substantial fellowship consideration

6.4 TOEFL and IELTS Benchmarks

English requirements are set almost universally as minimums with possible sub-scores, not as competition scales, though the practical effect in scholarship rounds is similar: the closer to the top of the scale, the fewer doubts your language ability raises. The combined table shows the two tests side by side at comparable levels of demand.

Table 7: TOEFL iBT and IELTS Academic benchmarks side by side

Level	TOEFL iBT total	IELTS overall band	Typical usage
Common stated floor	79-80	6.0-6.5	Fulbright recommends at least 79-80 iBT or 6.5; many universities state these minimums
Safe admission level	90-100	6.5-7.0	Comfortably above most floors; DAAD and Erasmus Mundus courses typically want this range
Competitive	100-110	7.0-7.5	Top universities and competitive scholarship shortlists
Strong	Above 110	7.5-8.0	Removes any language doubt; valuable for teaching assistantships

Watch sub-scores carefully: programs that involve teaching or heavy seminars often require Speaking of 22-25 on the TOEFL or 6.5-7.0 in every IELTS band regardless of the total. A total of 105 with Speaking 19 fails far more requirements than a balanced 95.

6.5 What Major Scholarships Actually Require

The table below summarizes published requirements for the most prominent international scholarship programs. Two caveats apply. Programs change requirements annually, so the official page for your application year is always the governing source. And for most scholarships, the English requirement shown is the minimum to be considered, while successful candidates usually present scores above it.

Table 8: Published test requirements of major scholarship programs

Program	Destination	English requirement	Aptitude test	Practical notes
Fulbright Foreign Student	USA	TOEFL iBT 79-80+ recommended (or IELTS 6.5, where accepted)	GRE frequently required for university placement	Selected candidates' GRE median is about 315; country commissions set exact rules
Chevening	UK	Set by host university, typically IELTS 6.5-7.5	Not required	An unconditional offer including its English condition is needed by the July deadline
Commonwealth Master's	UK	University-set, typically IELTS 6.5-7.0	Not required	Apply through national nominating agencies; development-impact essays weigh heavily
DAAD (EPOS and study scholarships)	Germany	Course-set, typically IELTS 6.0-7.0 or TOEFL 80-100	Rarely; a few engineering courses	English-taught development-related master's dominate; work experience often required
Erasmus Mundus Joint Masters	EU (multi-country)	Consortium-set, typically IELTS 6.5-7.0 or TOEFL 90-100	Rare; some quantitative programs accept or ask for GRE	Each consortium publishes its own score floors; check per program

Program	Destination	English requirement	Aptitude test	Practical notes
Australia Awards	Australia	IELTS 6.5 typical for university entry	Not required	Visa and university entry conditions apply; retest pathways exist
MEXT (Embassy and university track)	Japan	No fixed minimum; TOEFL/IELTS expected for English-taught courses	GRE for some graduate programs	Field-specific screening exams often matter more than language scores
US assistantships and university funding	USA	TOEFL 90-100+ or IELTS 7.0+ for funded roles	GRE 310-320+ strengthens applications	Teaching assistantships usually demand higher Speaking scores
MBA merit fellowships	USA, Europe, Asia	TOEFL 100+ or IELTS 7.0+	GMAT Focus 645+ (classic 700+) competitive	Fellowship committees combine scores with leadership profile

6.6 Keeping Scores Valid and Getting Them Where They Belong

Validity windows are fixed and unforgiving: GRE and GMAT scores last **five years** from the test date, while TOEFL and IELTS last **two years**, counted at the application deadline, not the enrollment date. This is the arithmetic reason the recommended sequence takes the aptitude test first and the English test second. Score sending has a free tier and a paid tier on every exam: the GRE allows four free reports on test day, the GMAT five free reports shortly after the score release, the TOEFL four free designations before the test, and IELTS five free copies after results. Extra reports cost modest per-copy fees.

Two reporting features can rescue imperfect histories. **ScoreSelect** on the GRE lets you send the best of your attempts and withhold earlier weaker ones, and the GMAT's reporting similarly transmits only the scores you choose, so retaking never exposes you to sending a worse result. **MyBest scores** on the TOEFL combine your best section performances across attempts within two years, but because not every program accepts MyBest, confirm the policy before counting on it. Finally, order reports early: institutions receive electronic

reports within days, but manual matching by slow admissions offices takes weeks, and scholarship deadlines are not extended for technicalities.

7. Policies, Retakes and Practical Logistics

7.1 Retake Rules Compared

Every exam allows multiple attempts, but each defines waiting periods, annual caps and reporting rules differently, and these details shape your testing calendar. The table compares the current published rules; all are stated on the official websites and should be re-checked at booking time.

Table 9: Retake and validity policies of the four exams

Rule	GRE	GMAT Focus	TOEFL iBT	IELTS Academic
Waiting period between attempts	21 days	16 days	Short interval (about 3 days); confirm current rule	No formal waiting period
Annual or lifetime cap	5 attempts per rolling 12 months	5 per 12 months, 8 lifetime	No formal cap	No formal cap
Score validity	5 years	5 years	2 years	2 years
Partial retake	Not offered	Not offered	Not offered	One Skill Retake where available (computer-delivered)
Best-score reporting	ScoreSelect: send chosen attempts	Send chosen scores	MyBest scores; some programs require single-date	All attempts visible if institution asks; new TRF per attempt

Strategically, two to three attempts per exam is the realistic norm: score research consistently shows most of the achievable gain arrives by the second or third sitting, after which additional attempts mostly purchase reassurance. Because ScoreSelect-type rules mean a weak attempt can be withheld from programs, there is little downside risk to a planned retake, apart from the fee and the calendar time, which is exactly why the roadmap in Chapter 8 leaves a retake window before deadlines.

7.2 Accommodations for Disabilities and Health Conditions

All four providers supply testing accommodations for documented disabilities and health conditions, including extended time, extra breaks, screen magnification, screen readers, and separate rooms. The process runs through the provider's accommodations office (ETS Disability Services for the GRE and TOEFL, GMAC for the GMAT, and the local British Council or IDP accommodations team for IELTS) and requires documentation from a qualified professional submitted well in advance, often four to twelve weeks before the intended date. Accommodations are approved before booking, not after, so applicants who need them should start the paperwork before choosing a test date, and should confirm that the approved accommodation is honored identically in at-home delivery if that is the preferred mode.

7.3 Common Mistakes and How to Avoid Them

The following failures appear so regularly in candidate forums and advising centers that they deserve explicit listing. Each is entirely preventable with attention at registration or planning time.

- **Name mismatches:** the account name, ID document and score report must match exactly; even a transposed name order can invalidate a test result or block score delivery.
- **Booking too late:** seats in high-demand cities and seasons disappear weeks ahead; a missed preferred date compresses the retake window to nothing.
- **Ignoring section minimums:** an overall 7.0 IELTS with Writing 5.5 fails programs requiring 6.0 per band, and a GRE total without the required Quantitative floor does the same.
- **Letting scores expire:** TOEFL and IELTS validity is counted at application; a test taken 25 months before enrollment is already dead paperwork.
- **Preparing on the wrong format:** drilling paper-based IELTS when you booked computer-delivered, or practicing without the online whiteboard you will use on an at-home GMAT, costs real points on exam day.
- **Skipping the free reporting:** free score reports are only available at or immediately around the test; forgetting them turns every later report into a fee.

8. Building Your Personal Testing Roadmap

8.1 A Twelve-Month Plan Working Backwards from Deadlines

Most scholarship deadlines cluster between September and January for enrollment the following autumn, which makes the twelve months before that window the natural testing period. The plan below assumes exactly that calendar; compress or stretch the phases proportionally if your deadlines differ. The guiding logic is fixed: English first in light preparation terms but not too early given the two-year validity, aptitude test in the middle with a retake cushion, and a fully free reporting strategy chosen before test days.

Table 10: Recommended twelve-month testing and application timeline

Months before deadlines	Phase	Key actions
12-11	Research	Shortlist programs and scholarships; record every minimum, section floor and accepted test into one spreadsheet
11-10	Diagnostics	Take free official practice tests for your chosen exams; set target scores at or above the competitive tier
10-8	English test cycle	Prepare 6-8 weeks; sit TOEFL or IELTS; keep a retake slot open 4 weeks later if a band falls short
8-5	Aptitude test cycle	Prepare 8-12 weeks with weekly mocks; first GRE/GMAT attempt at month 6; scheduled retake at month 5 if needed
5-4	Reports and referees	Finalize institution list; order score reports; request recommendation letters with clear instructions
4-2	Applications	Draft essays and research proposals; verify each application's test line against your spreadsheet

Months before deadlines	Phase	Key actions
2-0	Submission	Submit early rather than on deadline day; keep score PDFs and TRFs organized for upload requests

8.2 A Decision Checklist Before You Register

Before paying for anything, confirm the following decisions in writing, because each one either opens or closes options later.

- Destination and field: which countries and disciplines, since these determine GRE versus GMAT and sometimes dictate a specific English test.
- Requirement audit: for every target program and scholarship, the exact minimum, the competitive median, and any section floors, copied from official pages.
- Exam selection: one English test (TOEFL or IELTS) and at most one aptitude test (GRE or GMAT), unless a specific program genuinely demands both.
- Dates: registration date, test date, and a provisional retake date, all placed at least three weeks before the first hard deadline.
- Budget: registration fees, a retake reserve, materials, travel, and extra reports, checked against the fee reductions in Chapter 5.
- Reporting plan: the list of institutions to receive free reports on test day, finalized before the test, not after.

9. Frequently Asked Questions

The questions below are the ones advising centers and candidate communities answer most often. The answers condense the policy details given in earlier chapters; where a rule depends on your country, the pointer to the official source is included.

Do I need both an aptitude test and an English test?

In the overwhelming majority of cases, yes, if you are an international applicant applying to a program taught in English. The TOEFL or IELTS certifies language proficiency and the GRE or GMAT certifies academic reasoning; most universities and scholarship programs list them as separate requirements. A minority of programs waive the English test for applicants whose previous degree was taught in English, and a growing number of programs have dropped the GRE or GMAT entirely, so the requirement audit in Chapter 8 is the only reliable answer for your specific list.

Can I submit GRE scores instead of the GMAT for an MBA?

At most business schools today, yes: the GMAT and GRE are accepted interchangeably and committees convert scores for comparison. A few specialized finance or consulting-adjacent programs still lean toward the GMAT, and some MBA scholarships implicitly expect it, so check the school's class profile and scholarship terms. If you are applying to both MBA and non-MBA programs, the GRE remains the single-test strategy.

How long should I prepare for each exam?

Plan 100 to 200 hours for the GRE, 100 to 150 hours for the GMAT, and 40 to 100 hours for the TOEFL or IELTS, adjusted by your diagnostic results. Spread over realistic weekly commitments of 8 to 15 hours, an aptitude test needs 3 to 4 months of preparation and an English test 1 to 3 months. Intensity matters more than duration: six weeks of disciplined daily study outperforms six months of casual practice.

My score is below the minimum. Retake or change targets?

Diagnose first: if the gap is small (a few points on the GRE, half a band on IELTS) and time allows a retake before deadlines, retake with a changed study plan, because ScoreSelect-style reporting means the weak attempt can stay hidden. If the gap is large or time is short, retarget programs whose published minimums you meet, and remember that most scholarships weigh the whole file; a slightly lower test score with strong essays and references still wins places every year.

Are at-home test scores accepted by universities and scholarships?

Yes. At-home versions of the GRE, GMAT and TOEFL produce fully official scores that are reported identically to center scores, and they were used at enormous scale. IELTS Online is available only in some countries and a few institutions still restrict it. The only practical caveat is that a small number of highly competitive programs privately prefer center results, so if you have both options at reasonable cost, a center appointment removes any doubt.

What about the PTE Academic, Duolingo English Test or TOEFL Essentials?

These alternatives are legitimate and increasingly accepted: PTE Academic is computer-scored with results in about two days, the Duolingo English Test costs around US\$65 and runs at home, and TOEFL Essentials is a shorter, lower-cost ETS option. Acceptance is the deciding factor: universities accept them unevenly, and scholarship programs are more conservative than universities. Before choosing an alternative, confirm it appears on the accepted list of every scholarship you are targeting, not just the universities.

Do test scores expire, and when exactly?

GRE and GMAT scores are valid for five years from the test date. TOEFL and IELTS scores are valid for two years, and the controlling date is your application deadline, not enrollment. That is why the recommended sequence takes the English test within two years of applying, and why taking it three years before any application is wasted money.

Is there an age limit or prerequisite degree for these exams?

No. None of the four exams has an age limit, nationality restriction, or degree prerequisite; anyone can register and sit them. The practical gate is identification: a valid passport (or the locally approved ID) matching your registration name is required on exam day.

How many times should I take an exam?

Two to three attempts per exam is the effective ceiling for most candidates: research on retake patterns shows the bulk of possible improvement arrives by the third sitting. Beyond that, additional attempts rarely change admissions outcomes and consume money and calendar time better invested in essays, recommendations and program research. A disciplined candidate books the first date and a provisional retake date together, exactly as the roadmap in Chapter 8 suggests.

Are GRE Subject Tests still required anywhere?

Only rarely. Subject Tests in mathematics, physics and psychology continue to exist, and a small number of doctoral programs recommend or consider them, mostly in those exact fields. For master's admissions and for every scholarship program discussed in this guide, the GRE General Test is the relevant exam; check your specific PhD programs before investing in a Subject Test.

10. Final Recommendations

The four exams are administrative obstacles rather than intellectual trials, and they reward planning more than brilliance. The evidence assembled in this guide supports six concrete recommendations. Take the **English test first but not too early**, ideally 8 to 12 months before your deadlines, so the two-year validity is preserved and a retake remains possible. Prepare with **official materials as the core** and commercial courses as structure around them, and keep an error log from the first diagnostic to the last mock. Sit the **GRE or GMAT in the middle of the timeline** with a booked retake window, using ScoreSelect and equivalent reporting rules so that no weak attempt ever reaches a committee.

Target scores **above the stated minimums**: IELTS 7.0 or TOEFL 100, and GRE 315-320 or GMAT Focus 645+, put you inside the competitive band for the scholarship programs documented in Chapter 6, while the stated floors merely make you eligible. **Budget for the**

whole journey, roughly US\$600 to US\$1,200 including a retake and materials, and investigate the fee-reduction routes before paying full price. Finally, **confirm every requirement on official pages** in your application year, because programs do adjust minimums, accepted alternatives and section floors annually, and a single afternoon spent auditing requirements against a spreadsheet protects the entire investment this guide describes.